

# THE NEW LISTING LAUNCH CHECKLIST

From picking the right property to your first few weeks live -- what actually determines whether silence turns into bookings.

Zero bookings in the first few days is normal, not a sign something is wrong. What actually determines whether you start getting booked is two things: whether your property and your guest genuinely match, and how you use your first few weeks live. This checklist covers both in full -- the complete property-matching framework, every launch-week tactic, how to read your own performance data, and a worked example so you can see how it fits together in practice.

## BEFORE YOU EVEN GO LIVE -- THE MCB FRAMEWORK

No launch tactic later in this guide fixes a mismatch here. Micromarket, Customer, Budget -- get these three right and most of the "will anyone even book this" anxiety is already handled before you ever go live. This is the full framework, not a summary.

### M -- Micromarket

Do not think city. Think the exact thing that brings people to this specific area. Nobody books "Bangalore" -- they book near the office they are joining, or near the temple, or near the beach.

- Name the demand driver in one sentence -- a temple, a beach, an office campus, a hospital, a wedding venue. If you cannot name it in one sentence, you have not found a micromarket yet.
- Measure the actual distance to it. Walking distance, a short auto ride, or does it need a cab? This single factor moves your nightly rate more than almost anything you can do to the property itself.
- Check what already exists there. How many listings are already in this micromarket? Very few can mean untapped, or it can mean nobody stays here for a reason. Find out which before you commit.
- Understand the season. Every micromarket has a peak and a dead window. Know both before you commit, and know whether your dead window is two months or five.
- Draw the actual boundary. Write down the specific roads, landmarks, or radius you are searching within. If your search area is "the city," you have skipped this step.

### C -- Customer

This is where most first-time hosts lose money without realising it. Trying to serve every kind of guest produces a property that is acceptable to all of them and excellent for none.

- Write one sentence describing your guest -- who they are, why they are in this city, and who they are travelling with. If the sentence uses the word "anyone," start again.
- List what that guest cannot compromise on -- not what would be nice, but what would make them cancel or leave a bad review. That list is your property specification: bedrooms, kitchen, check-in timing, noise tolerance.
- Identify what you can safely skip. Every guest type has things they genuinely do not care about. This is where you save money without hurting reviews.
- Confirm that guest actually exists in your chosen micromarket. A retreat-style stay next to a tech park is a mismatch, however nice it looks -- your chosen guest and your chosen location have to match.

### B -- Budget

Budget is where most plans quietly break, because people budget for the property and the furniture and forget the third number entirely.

- Property cost: monthly rent plus security deposit (usually 2-3 months), or purchase cost if buying. Remember the deposit is locked up and unavailable once paid.
- Setup cost: furniture, appliances, AC, kitchen, linen, decor, professional photography. Typically Rs 2-2.5 lakh for a 2BHK. Do not cut photography to save money here.
- 90-day runway: rent, utilities, and operating costs for the first three months while reviews build and occupancy ramps. This is the number people miss most often.
- Know your break-even occupancy. At your rent and your expected nightly rate, what percentage occupancy covers your monthly costs? If that number is above 60 percent, the deal is fragile.

If any of M, C, or B feels shaky, fix that first. Everything on the next two pages can accelerate a good match. None of it can rescue a bad one.

## LAUNCH-WEEK TACTICS -- THE FULL LIST

| Tactic                            | Why It Matters                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Professional photography          | Photos are consistently the single biggest driver of clicks on a new listing. Airbnb offers a photography service in many cities, sometimes with the cost adjusted against your first booking rather than paid upfront -- worth checking before hiring separately. |
| Fast replies to enquiries         | Response speed is a ranking signal, not just a courtesy. A quick auto-acknowledgment followed by a real reply within the hour protects both your response-time stat and your actual conversion.                                                                    |
| Competitive, early pricing        | Price a genuine notch below comparable listings nearby for your first several bookings. You are not trying to maximise revenue yet -- you are trying to convert lookers into your first reviews.                                                                   |
| New-listing / early-bird discount | A discount in the range of 15-20% off for your first 3-5 bookings is a common, effective way to convert hesitant first bookers. Plan to remove it gradually once reviews start coming in, not all at once.                                                         |
| No unnecessary minimum stay       | A 3 or 5-night minimum on a brand-new listing filters out guests before they even consider you. Keep it flexible for the first few weeks, tighten it later once you have demand.                                                                                   |
| Instant Book turned on            | Listings with Instant Book enabled are shown to more searchers. Every manual approval step is a guest who books somewhere else while waiting.                                                                                                                      |
| Complete every listing field      | Unfilled amenities, a short description, or missing house rules all create gaps the algorithm and the guest both notice. A fully completed listing is treated as more trustworthy.                                                                                 |
| Update the listing every 30 days  | Calendar activity and small content refreshes are a signal that you are an active, engaged host, not a dormant listing. Adjust pricing, refresh a line of the description, or add a photo periodically.                                                            |
| Open the calendar far ahead       | A calendar open only a few weeks out is invisible to guests planning further ahead. Open at least 6 months, ideally 12, so you do not lose bookings to a closed calendar.                                                                                          |
| Ask every guest for a review      | A short, polite request sent right after check-out meaningfully increases how many guests actually leave one. Reviews are the single asset that carries you past the launch phase.                                                                                 |

## TRACK AIRBNB INSIGHTS

Airbnb Insights, inside your host dashboard, shows you how your listing is actually performing -- not guesswork. Most hosts never open it. The ones who do fix problems weeks earlier than the ones who do not.

- Search impressions vs. actual clicks. Low clicks on decent impressions usually means your photos or price need work, not your product.
- Conversion rate -- how many people who view your listing actually book. This is closer to the metric that determines whether you get shown to more people going forward.
- Comparable listings nearby, which Insights often shows directly, so you know if you are priced or positioned out of line with what is actually working around you.
- Response rate and response time, tracked continuously. A slipping response time is often the first sign that a launch is going off track, well before bookings visibly drop.

## HOW THIS LOOKS IN PRACTICE -- A WORKED EXAMPLE

To make this concrete: here is how the framework plays out for a host launching a 2BHK near a business district, aimed at short-stay corporate travellers.

| Step        | What It Looked Like                                                                                                                                                                    |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Micromarket | Property is a 10-minute walk from a large tech campus -- not just "in the same city" as the campus.                                                                                    |
| Customer    | One sentence: a working professional in the city for 2-4 nights who wants a fast, quiet, self-check-in stay close to work.                                                             |
| Budget      | Rent + deposit, Rs 2.2 lakh setup including photography, and a separate 90-day runway set aside and untouched.                                                                         |
| Week 1 live | Instant Book on, no minimum stay, 20% new-listing discount, calendar opened 9 months out, fast replies to every enquiry within the hour.                                               |
| Week 2-4    | Checked Insights twice a week. Clicks were healthy but conversion was low -- price was adjusted down slightly and the cover photo was swapped for a stronger one.                      |
| Result      | First booking arrived within the first two weeks. By the end of month two, the calendar was substantially filled, and the discount was already being eased back up as reviews came in. |

Nothing here was luck. Every step was a direct application of the framework above -- the property matched the guest before launch, and every launch-week lever was pulled deliberately rather than left to chance.

## The Full Checklist, In Short

- Micromarket: pick a location genuinely close to a real demand driver, not just in the right city.
- Customer: define one guest in one sentence, and design the property around them.
- Budget: cost out property, setup, and a 90-day runway -- all three, not just the first two.
- Get professional photography before you launch.
- Reply fast -- auto-acknowledge instantly, follow up for real within the hour.
- Price a notch below comparable listings for your first several bookings.
- Run a 15-20% new-listing discount for your first 3-5 bookings, then ease it off.
- Drop unnecessary minimum-stay restrictions in the first few weeks.
- Turn on Instant Book.
- Complete every field in your listing -- amenities, description, house rules.
- Refresh something in your listing every 30 days to stay active in the algorithm's eyes.

- Open your calendar 6-12 months ahead.
- Ask every guest for a review right after check-out.
- Check Airbnb Insights weekly -- impressions, clicks, conversion, response time, and nearby comparables.

None of this guarantees a booking on day one. All of it meaningfully improves your odds in the weeks that matter most.

## **Common Mistakes That Quietly Delay Bookings**

- Launching with a high minimum stay because it feels "safer." It does the opposite -- it removes you from most guest searches before you have any reviews to justify the restriction.
- Pricing at or above the market average on day one. Without reviews, you are asking a guest to trust a stranger at full price. Price is the only lever you fully control before your first reviews exist.
- Slow replies in week one. A guest choosing between two similar listings will usually book whichever host answers first -- this is often decided within the first hour, not the first day.
- Leaving the calendar closed beyond a few weeks. Guests planning ahead simply never see you, regardless of how good the listing is.
- Giving up on the discount too early or removing it all at once. A sudden price jump right after your first review can stall momentum just as it is building.
- Not checking Insights at all, and only noticing a problem once weeks have passed with no bookings.

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Based on research and personal experience. Please do your own research as well.

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